

Candidate Briefing Pack - BU Partners

AI & Data Engineer

Why This Role Is Exciting

- This is a founding hire into a brand-new internal function. You are not backfilling a seat or joining an established team with existing processes. You help define how the function works.
- The company is one of the largest and most active mid-market private equity investors in the German-speaking region, deploying a fund in the multi-billion euro range, with a strong, multi-decade track record of transactions across software, industrial tech, business services, and healthcare.
- Leadership has made a deliberate strategic bet: instead of buying off-the-shelf AI tools or staying dependent on external vendors, they want to build proprietary, in-house data and AI capability that becomes real intellectual property for the firm.
- The logic: AI models themselves are becoming commoditised. The real competitive edge over time comes from owning the data, the workflows, the institutional know-how, and the tooling built around those models, not from whichever model happens to be best this quarter. Firms that fully outsource this thinking risk ending up indistinguishable from every competitor using the same generic AI platform.
- You get to build the whole stack from a blank page: first the data foundations, platform, and pipelines, then the agentic tools that sit on top. Very few roles let you own both layers.
- Practically, this means you build things that materially change how a ~100-person investment firm sources deals, screens opportunities, runs diligence, monitors portfolio companies, and reports to investors. Visible, measurable impact rather than invisible backend engineering.
- You'll have direct, regular access to senior investment professionals and leadership, sit in on real deal and portfolio discussions, and build a genuine network in the private equity and investment world, without needing a finance background to get in the door.
- There is a lot of room to grow. The firm expects to keep growing this function, so early hires who show leadership potential have a real path to eventually help build and run the team.
- It's a high-autonomy, low-bureaucracy environment. Decisions get made quickly, you'll have real freedom over your own tech stack and how you build, and you won't be stuck waiting on layers of approval.

About the Company

- A leading mid-market private equity investor, headquartered in Zug (Switzerland), with additional offices in Munich, Milan, Amsterdam, and London.
- Currently deploying a fund in the multi-billion euro range (low single-digit billions), making it one of the largest mid-cap private equity investors in the DACH region.
- Track record of roughly 200 completed transactions, the large majority of which were

primary deals (i.e., no previous institutional investor involved). A sign of strong proprietary deal sourcing rather than just buying assets at auction.

- Invests across four core verticals: software, industrial technology, business services, and healthcare. It is one of the most active software investors in continental Europe.
- Around 100 people firmwide, roughly half of whom sit on the investment team, the other half in corporate/enabling functions.
- The firm has an internal "value creation" team of specialists who work directly inside portfolio companies on projects like AI adoption, pricing, and commercial strategy. So there's already a strong internal culture of hands-on operational involvement, not just capital allocation.
- The firm's data foundation is currently minimal: files live on SharePoint/OneDrive and there is no data warehouse or central data platform.
- Current AI tool usage across the firm is high but unstructured: individual teams and people have been building their own ad hoc AI-based solutions (including general-purpose enterprise AI tools and a PE-specific AI platform), but these aren't scalable, aren't documented, and don't transfer between people or deals.
- That's the gap this role is designed to close.

The Mandate: Data Foundations First, Then an Internal AI "Tool Factory"

- The firm wants to move from scattered files and individual AI usage to a structured, institutionalised internal capability: a proper data platform, and a small internal team that builds, owns, and maintains AI tooling across the whole deal lifecycle on top of it.
- The sequencing matters. Agentic tools are only as good as the data and context underneath them, so the first priority is getting the foundations right: assessing what infrastructure is actually needed, building the platform, and getting reliable pipelines in place.
- Once that backbone exists, the focus shifts to the agentic layer: turning real investment workflows into production-grade AI tools, rather than one-off experiments.
- The inspiration is similar to what some consulting and professional services firms have done in response to AI: building a repeatable, structured process for turning real workflows into production-grade tools.
- The problem this function needs to solve isn't a shortage of ideas. It's the opposite. Once this function exists, there will likely be a flood of requested use cases from the investment team. Prioritisation and focus will be a core skill, not just technical execution.
- Example use cases span the full deal lifecycle: deal sourcing and personalised outreach at scale, screening and scraping data rooms during diligence, building and iterating financial models, drafting investment memos and IC papers, quarterly portfolio valuations, portfolio monitoring, and investor reporting.
- A simple illustration leadership has used internally: using AI well could let the firm send several times more personalised outreach letters with a fraction of the junior staff currently needed to do it manually.
- Success will be measured concretely: a working data foundation, adoption of tools across the investment team, measurable efficiency gains, and a formal data and AI strategy taking shape within the first year.

The Role

- The firm is hiring an AI & Data Engineer to build this function from the ground up. The role has two layers, broadly in this order:
- **Data foundations:** assessing what data infrastructure the firm actually needs, then designing and building the data platform and pipelines. That means pulling data out of SharePoint/OneDrive, data rooms, portfolio reporting, and the firm's existing systems into a structured, reliable, well-modelled backbone that the AI tools and the wider investment team can build on.
- **The agentic layer:** translating how investment professionals actually work into structured, scoped, buildable tools, then building, shipping, and maintaining them. Heavy emphasis on agentic coding tools, prompt and context engineering, and integration work (MCP servers, APIs) rather than model training or open-ended research.
- Importantly, the firm is open to "skill spikes". If a strong candidate leans more towards data engineering, or more towards AI/agentic engineering, that's genuinely fine as long as they can credibly cover both layers. The intent is to hire based on actual strengths, not to force-fit every candidate into a rigid job description.
- If you have a skillset that's adjacent to, but not a perfect match for, this profile, that is worth flagging rather than ruling yourself out.

What Good Looks Like: What Makes a Strong Hire Here

This is the part I'd genuinely pay attention to. Based on repeated conversations with the hiring team, here's what consistently comes up as differentiating a strong fit from a weak one:

- Translator mindset, not just builder mindset. The single most emphasised trait is the ability to sit with non-technical, senior, and often strong-willed business stakeholders, understand what they actually need (not just what they ask for), and turn that into a scoped, buildable tool. Purely technical candidates without this consulting/translation instinct tend not to land well here.
- Genuine technical depth and engineering hygiene. This is not a "prompt engineering only" role. Real production-grade practices matter: solid data modelling, reliable pipelines, data quality, version control, testing, documentation, and packaging, so that someone else could pick up and maintain what you build. A solid computer science foundation (formal or self-taught but demonstrable) is valued specifically because it supports long-term maintainability, not because anyone wants to see a fancy CV.
- Comfortable operating with real ambiguity and no technical manager nearby. There is currently no CTO, CIO, or Head of Data at the firm. Whoever joins will need to exercise independent technical judgement, including on the data architecture itself, often against input from multiple senior stakeholders with strong opinions, without someone technical above them to lean on day to day.
- Business-savvy and consulting-oriented backgrounds tend to translate well. Backgrounds in data or technology implementation consulting, forward-deployed or embedded engineering roles, RevOps, business/systems analysis, generalist operations consulting, or professional services/customer success at a software company are all seen as strong

preparation. Often more so than a pure engineering background with no stakeholder-facing experience.

- Confidence without dogmatism. You'll need to stand in front of experienced, opinionated investment professionals and hold your ground on technical or process points, while still driving outcomes through consensus rather than force. Being overly attached to your own ideas, or conversely being too passive to push back when needed, are both seen as risks.
- A genuine interest in how private equity deal-making actually works (sourcing, diligence, value creation, reporting, exit) is valued. You don't need prior finance experience, but real curiosity about the business context matters a lot, since the job is fundamentally about embedding in that world.
- An internal "adoption champion" instinct. Part of the job is proactively going to colleagues' desks, demonstrating tools, and lowering the barrier to actual usage, not just shipping something and hoping people find it. People who enjoy that kind of hands-on internal advocacy tend to thrive; people who prefer to stay heads-down and hand off finished work to someone else typically don't.
- An entrepreneurial, ownership-driven mindset. As a founding hire, you'll likely help shape the function's strategy and may eventually help build out the wider team. This suits people who want to build something from a blank page, not people looking for a well-defined, static role.
- Resilience and staying power in a fast, transactional environment (see culture section below), and realistic expectations about pace and responsiveness.

Culture and Working Environment

- The investment team is fast-paced, hard-working, young, ambitious, and made up of strong personalities who are used to advocating firmly for their own views. This role sits close to that team, so some resilience is genuinely required.
- There is no formal face-time culture. The firm cares about results, not hours logged at a desk. Getting things done within a normal working day is entirely acceptable.
- That said, this is not a strict 9-to-5 role. If you build a pipeline or a tool, you own it. If it breaks, you're expected to be reachable and responsive, and there will be periods where longer hours are needed to hit a deadline or fix something live. Ownership and responsiveness are the core expectation, more than fixed hours.
- Worth being candid about: when candidates have led with questions about working hours very early in initial conversations, that's been flagged internally as a potential culture-fit concern. Not disqualifying on its own, but worth being aware of how that question can land in this context, and worth being thoughtful about when and how you raise work-life balance topics in process.
- The environment is genuinely low-bureaucracy. Decisions get made quickly, and there's a lot of trust placed in the people doing the work.

Team Structure and Reporting

- This is a newly-forming function. There is currently no CTO, CIO, or Head of Data at the firm, so this hire will not have a technical manager immediately above them.
- The plan is to bring more than one person into this function rather than hiring one person and waiting, so you'd be joining alongside at least one peer from day one, not working in

isolation.

- The function will report into a senior member of the investment team who is sponsoring this initiative, rather than into a technical leadership structure.
- Because there's no senior technical leadership in place yet, the firm is conscious of retention risk for very junior hires without technical mentorship nearby. That's part of why they're looking for candidates with real seniority and independent judgement, not just raw technical skill.
- Longer term, there is a clear expectation that this function grows, and that early hires who show leadership capability could grow into leading that wider team.

Location, Language, and Work Model

- The role is based out of Munich, with Zug (Switzerland) also relevant given the firm's headquarters there.
- Hybrid/work-from-home options exist, but this is not a remote-first role. Regular in-person presence, especially early on, matters for building trust with the investment team. The default is on-site, typically 5 days per week with flexibility for WFH when needed but not by default.
- Fluency in both English and German is required, given the day-to-day working environment.

Interview Process

- Initial conversation(s) with the recruiter (that's me). A genuine two-way conversation to understand your background, motivations, and fit, not just a formality, and designed to save you time by flagging early if something isn't going to be a fit before you invest in later rounds.
- Intro interview with the firm's Head of Talent.
- Investment Team Interview: meeting with one member of the investment team to discuss their use cases and go into your relevant project experience.
- A case study. This has looked like a focused, time-boxed build exercise (for example, building a small cloud-based tool within a couple of hours). Where possible and timelines allow, this is done in person in Munich; virtual is also an option to keep the process moving.
- A deeper technical interview, run by an external technical advisor who works with the firm. This is where real technical depth, across both data and AI engineering, gets pressure-tested.
- A final conversation with the senior sponsor of the initiative on the investment team.
- The firm is conscious of moving efficiently and not over-processing candidates, so the exact number and order of steps can flex somewhat depending on the candidate and timeline.

The Technology Environment (For Context)

- The firm deliberately favours simple, maintainable tooling over cutting-edge or overly custom architecture, so that someone else could reasonably understand and operate what's been built after a short handover.

- Data layer: currently files on SharePoint/OneDrive with no warehouse. Part of the job is deciding what the right, proportionate data platform looks like for a ~100-person firm, and building the pipelines to feed it.
- Illustrative stack for lighter in-house tools: a database plus a Python backend, basic HTML/CSS/JS for internal dashboards and review tools, and MCP servers/APIs for integration into the firm's existing software landscape.
- Standard software engineering practices are expected throughout: git/version control, automated testing, and packaging/documentation of both the business and technical context behind each pipeline and tool.
- On the AI/LLM side: agentic coding tools (e.g., Claude Code, Codex-style tools), prompt and context engineering, and workflow automation platforms (e.g., n8n, Make) rather than custom model training.
- The firm deliberately wants to stay model-agnostic, relying on strong internal context, data, and tooling rather than being locked into any one AI vendor or model provider, since they see that flexibility as increasingly important as the underlying models themselves become more commoditised.

A Few Honest Things Worth Knowing Going In

- This is a builder role first, not a pure strategist or pure coder role. If you want to spend your time only writing code with a finished spec handed to you, or only doing high-level strategy without hands-on building, this probably isn't the right fit.
- The early months will likely be weighted towards data foundations: pipelines, data modelling, and getting information out of scattered files. If you only want to work on the agentic layer, be honest with yourself about that.
- You will be one of the first people in this function, without an existing technical playbook to follow. Some candidates find that exciting, others find it stressful. Worth being honest with yourself about which camp you're in.
- The investment team culture is direct and results-driven. If you prefer a slower-paced, highly structured corporate environment, it's worth weighing that against what's described above.
- If any of this raises questions or concerns, better to raise them with me early in the process than to discover a mismatch later. I'd rather help you make a well-informed decision than just push you through a process.